My Off-Grid Diary

One simple project. Completely out of hand!

Ages 13–16

My Off-Grid Diary

Sunday: An easy assignment. Obviously.

Our teacher said, 'Choose an environmental issue and spend a week exploring it.' I picked the Arabian leopard. I thought drawing it would be the hardest part.

Ten minutes later...

I drew two ears and a tail.

My friend asked, 'Why is your cat so grumpy?"

The problem was, I wanted to finish the project before I understood it.

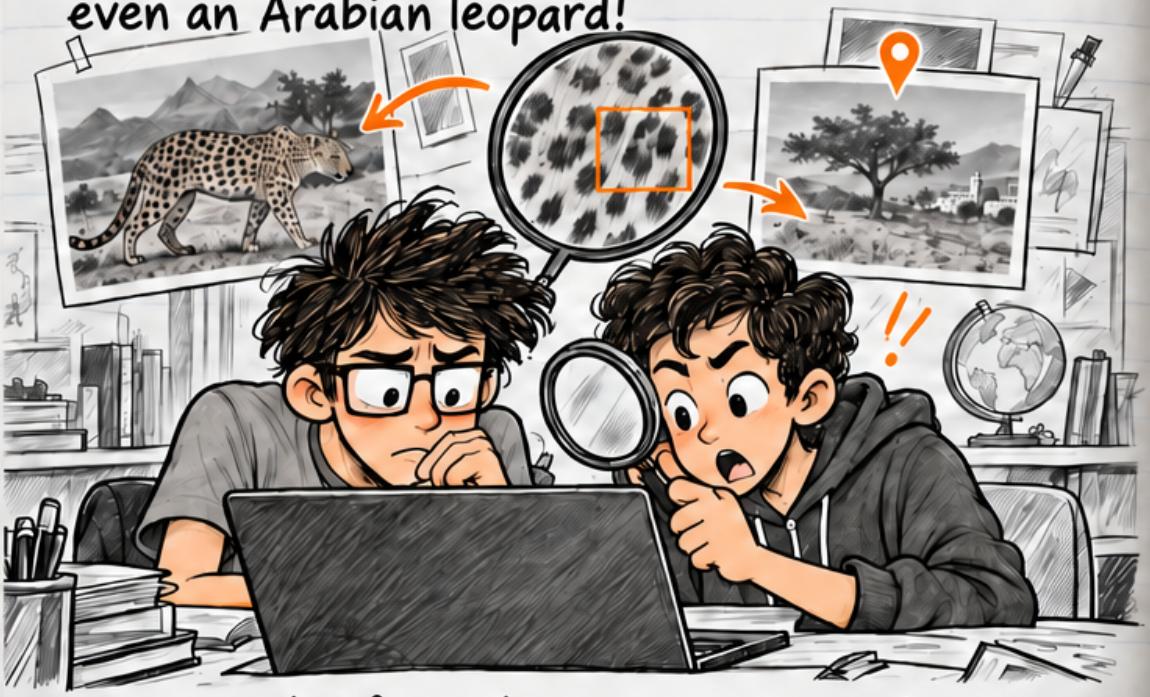
Note to self: Research first. Drawing later.

Monday: An expert in five minutes

I'm Salem. I'm fourteen. I found a photo captioned: 'Arabian leopard spotted near the city.' I sent it to Rashid immediately.

The photo that travelled further than I did

We tracked down the original photo. It was old, taken somewhere else, and the animal wasn't even an Arabian leopard!



I removed it from the presentation and sent Rashid a correction.

Great. Now fix your drawing.

Lots of shares don't make a claim true.

Tuesday: Questions, not headlines

We read about the Arabian leopard in reliable scientific sources. A habitat isn't just a pretty background. It's where an animal finds food and shelter.

Wednesday: A trip without a selfie

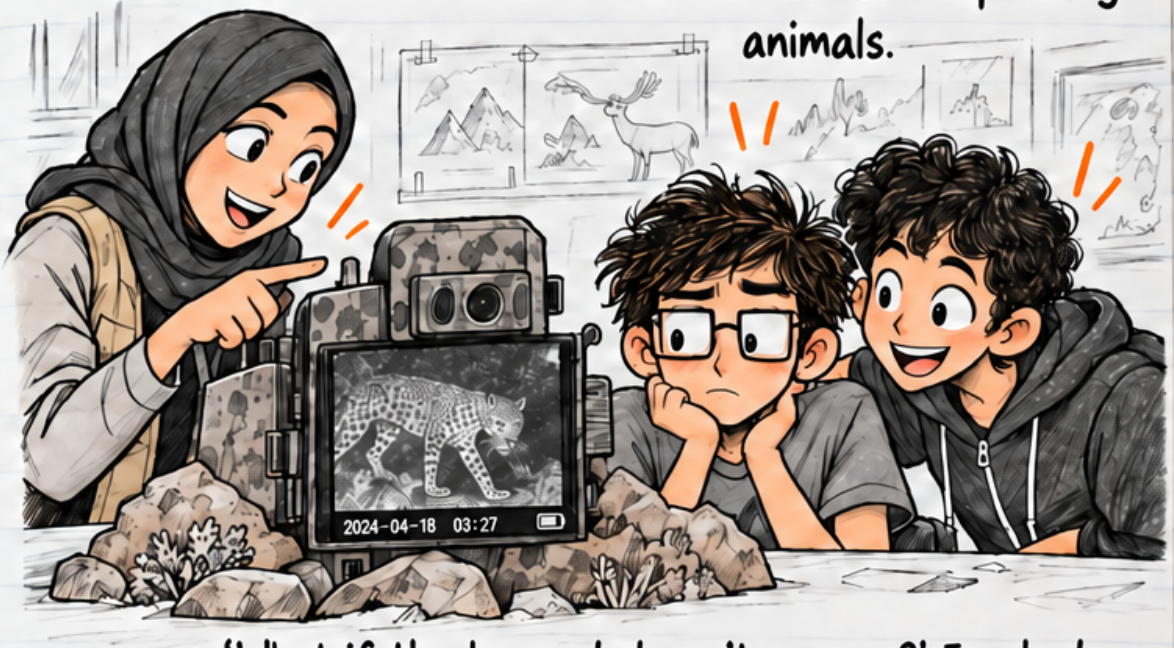
Our class visited a nature education centre.
I asked our guide, Reem, 'When do we get to see the leopard?'
She said, 'Today we'll learn how specialists study it.
Wild animals don't follow our school timetable.'

A learning visit. Not a chase!

Clearly, the leopard hadn't read the school notice.

A camera that won't ask you to smile

Reem showed us camera-trap photos. Specialists place these cameras in selected locations to record passing animals.



'What if the leopard doesn't appear?' I asked.
'We review the evidence and keep studying,' she said.
'Missing from one photo doesn't mean missing from the area.'

Protect the leopard. Protect its home.

I drew mountains, plants and animals, then placed the leopard among them. Reem said, 'Leopards need a healthy habitat and wild prey. Everything here is connected.'

We can't save the picture and forget the place.

People are part of the solution

Rashid asked, 'What about the people who live there, and their livestock?'

Reem said, 'That's why specialists work with local communities. We listen to their concerns and find ways to reduce harm to people and wildlife.'

I crossed out 'The solution is easy.'
It was the easiest sentence in my notebook.
And the least useful.

Thursday: The brilliant plan, version two

I suggested a campaign called 'Save the leopard!'

Rashid asked, 'And what are we asking people to do?'

Silence. I'd finished the headline before I'd thought of the idea.

We agreed on a small exhibition: reliable facts, a habitat game, and a drawing explaining what we'd learned.

This time, we listed our sources before choosing the colours.

Smaller headline. More work.

Sunday: One minute to present

The screen lit up. Our first slide appeared.
Someone at the back called out, 'Why have you put a tiger there?'
I froze. I'd used an old picture from my draft folder.
Rashid whispered, 'Got a backup plan?'

From assignment to a cause

We corrected the picture and shared what we'd learned about the leopard and its habitat.

'How will you help?' our teacher asked.

'By raising awareness among our classmates,' I said. 'Protecting the leopard means protecting its habitat and the wildlife connected to it.'

We invited everyone to our Nature Corner: stories, reliable information and activities we could all take part in.

One week later: Off-grid

The project had been graded. But we kept our Nature Corner in the classroom and added a notebook for everyone's questions.

That weekend, I went out with my family. I put my phone in my bag and sat down to draw the mountains. I didn't see a leopard. And I didn't claim that I had.

When we got home, I sent Rashid my new drawing.

What do you think?

This one actually looks like a leopard.

Progress. Scientific AND artistic.

Final note: The notebook is full. The questions keep coming.

Salem wants to finish a school project with minimum effort. One ready-made picture, one big headline. Done.

But a questionable photo, a friend with too many questions, and a presentation that goes off-script change everything.

A school assignment becomes a cause as two friends discover that protecting the Arabian leopard starts with understanding its habitat and speaking up for wildlife.

Concept by Jumanah Alsubaie

A fictional story informed by nature conservation.